

PITTSBURGH TRIBUNE-REVIEW

Model railroad club expanding display

By Eric Slagle
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Thursday, November 25, 2010

Call it a work in progress.

The McKeesport Model Railroad Club is in the midst of what might be described as a system overhaul that is expanding the scope of its miniaturized railroad display.

“Anybody who hasn’t seen this in the last year is in for a big surprise,” club president Dean Liberty said of the club’s massive HO gauge layout, known as the Mon-Yough Valley Railroad.

Indeed, those who visit the annual Christmastime open house at the club’s headquarters at 2209 Walnut St. will get a behind-the-scenes look at some of the super-structure that supports the miniature reproduction of an industrial rail system, circa 1960.

Wood scaffolding, track and wires are visible in significant sections of the display this year. The layered and elevated sections of track occupy what, at this time last year, had been just open floor space. In some places, the structure has been covered with a pink papering material that later will be decorated to look like mountainside. At other places, the names of fictional streets and towns have been penciled onto wooden slats. Club members are sticklers for detail.

It all amounts to a cutaway look that anyone who’s ever been fascinated by large model railroad displays will appreciate.

Liberty, who lives in Port Vue, said the system should be restored in total by next year. In the 12 months that have just gone by, he said club members have poured hundreds of hours into the project.

“We’re here year round,” he said.

Sam Russell of Penn Hills is one of the members who spends much time at the club. During a recent visit he was laying track leading to Steelton, one of the display’s fictional Western Pennsylvania towns.

“My uncle turned me on to trains when I was 2 or 3 years old,” said Russell, who is now 52. Though Russell said he loves the nostalgic feel of the club’s layout, he added he is also a collector of modern model trains.

On the same visit, member Bill Wilson of Baldwin was checking the wiring on a new portion of track. Wilson, who will turn 90 in December and is the oldest member of the club, said he prefers the older style model trains.

“Steam is my favorite because that is what I grew up with,” said Wilson, adding he loved

watching the trains in Hazelwood while growing up in that neighborhood.

Though model trains may not be the most modern of hobbies, some juvenile members are part of the club’s 25. The minimum age for joining the club is 7. A few of the members already have introduced family members who are even younger than that to model trains.

Tony Kingera, for example, brought his 14-month-old daughter Natalie over to the club for a recent visit and the little girl was clearly enjoying the trains as they made their way around the room.

“She’s just learning about trains,” said Kingera, who is treasurer for the club.

Liberty said he thinks model trains have become less popular than they used to be, in part because of their expense. Model trains aren’t cheap, he said, and having a sizable display can quickly become a hobby only the well-heeled can afford. He noted the purpose of model train clubs, like the one in McKeesport which was founded in 1950, was for average people to have access to the hobby.

“This display doesn’t belong to anybody. It belongs to the members,” he said.

The display opens Friday from 5-10 p.m.

Hours of operation through the holiday season are 7-10 p.m. on Fridays from Dec. 3-17.

Saturday hours are noon-5 p.m. from this Saturday to Dec. 11 and noon-7 p.m. on Dec. 18. Sunday hours from this Sunday to Dec. 12 are noon-5 p.m. and on Dec. 19 the hours are noon-6 p.m.

The club asks that visitors 18 and older make a \$3 donation, children ages 5-17 are asked to make a \$2 donation and children under 5 are free.

For more information about the club, visit its website at www.mckeesportmodelrr.org.

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